By the time we finished our work, it was already morning. Suddenly, at the breakfast table, I remembered that I was to attend my niece Zameela's wedding at Rameswaram that evening. I thought it was already too late to do anything. Even if I could catch the Madras flight later in the day, how would I reach Rameswaram from there? There was no air link between Madras and Madurai from where I could board the evening train to Rameswaram. A pang of guilt dampened my spirits. Was it fair, I asked myself, to forget my family commitments and obligations? Zameela was more like a daughter to me. The thought of missing her wedding because of professional preoccupations at Delhi was very distressing. I finished breakfast and left for the meeting.

When we met Defence Minister Venkataraman and showed him our revised proposal, he was visibly pleased. The proposal of the missile development project had been turned overnight into the blueprint of an integrated programme with far-reaching consequences. It would have wide-ranging technological spinoffs, and was exactly what the Defence Minister had had in mind the previous evening. Notwithstanding the great respect I had for the Defence